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Going Independent

What it means to be an independent consultant

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ABOUT ME

Engineer before consultant

WVU: B.S. 2006, M.S. 2008

ASF

Apache Software Foundation Member and Apache OpenNLP PMC Chair

TSC

Member of the OpenSearch Technical Steering Committee

25

cloud certifications (17 AWS, 8 Google Cloud)

Go looking for the hard problems. That’s where you’ll learn the most.

MY JOURNEY

A non-linear path

AGE ~15

Started a company

A software company I worked through college.

AFTER COLLEGE

The employee years

NASA, FBI, Leidos, etc. Always working to get back to self-employed.

2018

Self-employed again

Started taking on independent work.

2019

Fully independent

Consulting became the whole job.

2026

Consulting today

Search, NLP, and cloud consulting.

Working at "real" jobs provides valuable experience and knowledge.

WHAT IT MEANS

An independent consultant is a business of one.



You sell it

Find clients, understand their problem, scope the work, set your rate.



You deliver it

Do the expert work, and be the person accountable for the result.



You run it

Contracts, invoices, taxes, and insurance.

Don’t let the business side scare you – there are resources available.

WHAT I ACTUALLY DO

Specialize so clients know when to call you



Search engineering

Relevance tuning, OpenSearch, migrations



NLP and AI

Language models, text processing, ML pipelines



Cloud and data

AWS and GCP architecture, streaming data engineering



Governance and compliance

PII redaction, HIPAA, secure pipelines

THE TRADE-OFFS

Being independent comes with responsibility

What's great

- You choose your clients and projects
- You set your own schedule
- You learn across many industries
- Your name is the brand
- You decide how you work

What's hard

- Income can be irregular
- No paid vacation *
- Staying current requires effort
- Change can be difficult
- Continually looking for work

** You can pay yourself for time off and track PTO, if that's important to you.*

BUILDING A REPUTATION

Doing the work in public



Open source

Apache OpenNLP PMC Chair, OpenSearch TSC member and maintainer



Speaking

OpenSearchCon, Community Over Code, Open Source Summit, PyData



Writing

Blog posts, plus 25 cloud certifications as proof of skill



Trust

Clients can check your work before they ever call you

As an independent, you have no company brand to lean on. **Public work becomes your portfolio.**

At this point, my website jeffzemerick.dev is my resume.

FINDING YOUR NICHE

Know your angle

Mine: empower companies by getting them past a hard problem.



Do the work

Solve the hard problem hands-on, alongside their team.

Document it

Leave behind clear write-ups so nothing lives only in my head.

Teach their staff

Make sure their people can own and extend it.

Move on

Leave them capable and independent, not dependent on me.

Find how you like to work and build that into your consulting, whether that means short engagements like mine, long-term partnerships, or something in between. It sounds counterintuitive, but short, successful engagements keep clients coming back for more.

PICKING A NICHE

“AI” is too broad. Get specific.

SPECIFIC PROBLEMS

Search and retrieval (RAG)
Help AI find and cite the right documents

LLM evaluation
Prove AI features work before launch

Privacy and PII
Keep sensitive data out of prompts

Governance and compliance
HIPAA, financial rules, the EU AI Act

Document processing
Extract data from contracts, claims, forms

Agents and integration
Connect AI safely to existing systems

Cost and performance
Smaller models, caching, self-hosting

AI security
Prompt injection, data leaks, misuse

SPECIFIC INDUSTRIES

- Healthcare
- Legal
- Finance
- Insurance
- Government
- Manufacturing

Knowing an industry’s vocabulary and regulations is often worth more than the technical skill.

Combine a specific problem with a specific industry: “document extraction for insurance claims”

IF YOU WANT TO CONSULT IN AI

Four things I'd tell my younger self

1. **Learn the unglamorous parts.** Data, cloud, security and compliance decide whether AI projects ship.

2. **Work in the open.** Contribute to open source, write, and give talks.

3. **Find your focus,** but keep your knowledge broad and be open.

4. **Going back and forth is ok.** Taking a full-time role between independent stretches is part of the path.

GETTING STARTED

What you can do today

THIS WEEK

- Think about your interests and your focus
- Create a simple personal website that will serve as your resume

THIS MONTH

- Make your first open-source contribution: docs, a test, or a small bug fix
- Write a short blog post about something you learned while doing it

THIS SEMESTER

- Build a small project in your niche and push it to GitHub
- Go to a meetup or conference and talk to people; make connections online and in-person

You don't need permission or a job title to start doing the work in public.
An open-source project or an industry conference isn't going to ask if you have a degree.
Think of yourself as an expert. If you don't, others won't either.

Questions?

Helping others matters to me. If you have questions later, feel free to email me or send me a message on LinkedIn.

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